



Goal Setting

What is it?

Goal setting is a process that helps you achieve the objective or aim of an action.



Goal setting is the most commonly used behaviour change skill. Being able to distinguish between and use different types of goals is an effective strategy to improve physical activity.

How does it work?

Goal setting will help you outline a plan of what you want to do, where you want to start, as well as how to continue. There are three types of goals you should know about. Whatever goal you end up setting for your physical activity will fall into one of these categories:

Learning Goals

Learning goals help you get started. They focus on simple tasks and simple plans to start being active.
For example: "I will start looking for gyms in my community where I can do endurance training."

Performance Goals

Performance goals are goals that you want to accomplish or continue doing in the short term.
For example: "For the next two weeks, I will come to the gym twice per week to walk on the treadmill."

Outcome Goals

Outcome goals focus on the overarching activity you want to achieve, or long-term aspirations.
For example: "I want to have better energy levels and be able to walk non-stop for 30 minutes without being out of breath."

To make your goals challenging and attainable, keep the following **aspects** of goal setting in mind:

Ability

You need to have the ability to achieve the goal.

Commitment

The goal has to be perceived as important to you.

Feedback

You should obtain feedback on goal attainment.

Situational Resources

You should have the resources for goal attainment.

CASE STUDY

Salma has a chronic medical condition that requires her to be supervised at a fitness centre while doing physical activity. She tells her physical activity instructor that she wants to be able to walk every day without the fear of falling (**outcome goal**).

Her physical activity instructor asks Salma how she wants to get started. She replies,



I want to come in to use the gym twice per week, on Monday and Wednesday at 3pm (**performance goal**). But I need to figure out the bus schedule to get here, so I'll do that before next Monday (**learning goal**).



Your Turn

How do you use it?

1. Choose a goal type

What type(s) of goal(s) are right for me?

- **Learning goal:** What tasks do you need to do to become active?
- **Performance goal:** What activities do you want to do in the next week or two?
- **Outcome goal:** What activities do you want to continue doing in the long-term?

What type of goal do you want to set?

- ☐ Learning Goal
- ☐ Performance Goal
- ☐ Outcome Goal

2. Create a goal

While creating a goal, consider the following:

- Is my learning goal helping me get started?
- Is my performance goal helping me to accomplish larger outcome goals?
- Am I challenging myself with this goal?

Write your goal(s) in the space provided:

Why is this goal(s) important to me?



Reflection – *Goal Setting*

Reflect on your experience practicing and using goal setting this week. Use this space to write your overall impressions of using this skill. Respond to the reflection questions below:

- What have you enjoyed / not enjoyed about using goal setting?
- Do you need to change anything about your goal(s)?
- How do you see yourself using goal setting in the future?